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What is Poverty?

- Jo Goodwin Parker

* Understanding the textAnswer the following questions.

a) What is poverty according to Parker?

Ans. According to Parker, poverty is much more than a low bank balance; it is a total loss of dignity and hope. She defines it through the senses: the smell of 'sour laundry,' the taste of 'monotonous' cornmeal, and the feeling of 'persistent cold.' To her, poverty is a state of being trapped in a cycle of filth and exhaustion where a person is constantly reminded that they are 'different' and 'lesser' than the rest of society.

b) How is poverty difficult for Parker's children? List some specific examples.

Ans. Poverty attacks her children's health and happiness. They suffer from malnutrition, evidenced by their "distended bellies" and a diet lacking protein. They face constant physical discomfort, like 'chronic' 'diaper rash' and 'runny noses,' because Parker cannot afford soap or medicine. Beyond physical pain, they experience social shame; they are often mocked by other child-

ren for their ragged clothes and the 'smell of poverty' that follows them to school.

c) How does Parker try to obtain help, and what problems does she encounter?

Ans Parker tries to seek help through welfare offices and private charities, but she is met with cruel 'red tape' and judgement. When she asks for aid, she is often told to 'come back tomorrow' or find a baby-sitter she can't afford. She encounters caseworkers who treat her with suspicion instead of kindness. Often, the requirements to get help - like having a permanent address or a phone - are things she already lost because she is poor.

d) Why are people's opinions and prejudices her greatest obstacles?

Ans Prejudices are her biggest hurdle because they lead to indifference and a lack of real support. When people judge her as 'lazy' or 'dirty', they feel justified in not helping. These opinions create a 'wall' between her and the resources she needs. Parker argues that it is easier for people to blame the poor for their situation than to admit that the system is broken, which leaves her isolated and without a voice.

c) How does Parker defend her inability to get help? How does she discount the usual solutions society has for poverty (e.g. welfare, education, and health clinics)?

Ans Parker defends herself by showing that society's 'solutions' are unrealistic for someone in her position. She discounts welfare because the payments are too small to cover basic needs. She dismisses education as a solution because she has no way to pay for childcare or transport while she studies. She explains that 'health clinics' are useless when you have to wait all day in a hallway with sick children, losing a day's potential work or survival time.

• Reference to the content.

Q Explain the following:

Poverty is looking into a black future.

Ans In this essay, Parker describes a 'black future' as a state of total hopelessness. For most people, the future represents a chance for improvement - like getting a better job or finishing school. However, for a person living in extreme poverty, the future 'black' because it is a dark void where no change is possible. There is no money to save and no path to escape.

The 'blackness' also refers to the mental exhaustion that comes with being poor. When every bit of your energy is spent just trying to find the next meal or keep your children warm today, your mind loses the ability to dream about tomorrow. To Parker, the future isn't a place of potential; it is simply a repeat of today's hunger and cold. This lack of vision makes it impossible to plan for a better life.

By calling the future 'black', Parker communicates that she is trapped in a room with no windows and no exit, where the only thing she can be certain of is continued hardship for herself and her children.

b) What does Parker mean by 'The poor are always silent'?

Ans. Parker means that the poor have been stripped of their social and political voice. While they may physically speak, society chooses not to listen to them. They are ignored by the government and judged by the wealthy. In the essay, she explains that the poor are expected to be invisible and 'grateful' for whatever small help they receive, rather than complaining about their misery.

This silence is also a result of crushing shame. Parker describes how the lack of soap, decent clothes, and a clean home makes poor people want to hide away from the world. When you are constantly embarrassed by your appearance and your life, you stop speaking up. This self-imposed silence is a defense mechanism to avoid the harsh 'prejudices' and 'disgust' of those who are better off.

Finally, Parker suggests that society prefers the poor to be silent. If the poor stay quiet, the rest of the world can pretend that poverty is not a major problem. By writing this essay in the form of direct address, Parker is intentionally breaking the silence and forcing the reader to hear a voice that is usually buried.

c) What writing strategy does the author use at the beginning of most of the paragraphs? Do you notice a recurring pattern? What is it?

Ans. The author uses a powerful literary technique called Anaphora, which is the repetition of a phrase at the start of sentences. Almost every paragraph begins with the phrase 'Poverty is --' followed by a harsh, sensory reality (like "poverty is dirt"). This recurring pattern creates a relentless rhythm that mimics the never-ending nature of being poor.

This strategy serves to redefine poverty for the reader. Instead of letting the reader think of poverty as just a number or a statistic, she forces them to see it as a series of painful human experiences. By starting each paragraph this way, she builds a long list of suffering that covers everything from the smell of sour milk to the lack of medical care.

The pattern also ensures that the focus remains on the human element. Each 'Poverty is --' statement acts like a hammer blow, breaking down the reader's defenses. It creates a cumulative emotional impact, making it impossible for the reader to finish the essay without feeling the weight of her daily life and the total exhaustion of her spirit.

Q: How does Parker develop each paragraph? What details make each paragraph memorable?

Ans: Parker develops her paragraphs using intense sensory details. She doesn't just tell the reader she is poor; she makes them smell the 'sour stench' of unwashed clothes and feel the 'cracked' skin on her hands. Each paragraph focuses on a specific theme—like hygiene, health, or childcare—and fills it with vivid 'micro-details' that make the abstract concept of poverty feel very real.

Furthermore, she uses personal anecdotes to ground her arguments. For example, she describes her children's 'runny noses' and 'swollen bellies' to illustrate the failure of the healthcare system. These details are memorable because they appeal to the reader's emotions. It is hard for a reader to ignore the image of a mother who cannot even afford a jar of Vaseline for her baby's rashes.

Lastly, she develops her ideas by showing the cause and effect of poverty. She explains how the lack of soap leads to dirt, which leads to sickness, which leads to a lack of work, which leads back to more poverty. This logical development shows the reader that her situation is not a result of 'laziness,' but a complete trap where every small problem creates a much larger disaster.

Q In the final paragraph, how does the author use questions to involve the reader in the issue of poverty?

Ans In the final paragraph, Jo Goodwin Parker shifts her tone from personal description to direct confrontation. She uses a series of "Rhetorical Questions," such as "can you be silent too?" and "can you see?" to bridge the gap between her world and the reader's. These questions are designed to pull the reader out of their role as a passive observer and force them to take a moral stand.

These questions serve to destroy the reader's comfort and indifference. Throughout the essay, the reader has been a silent witness, but the final questions turn them into a participant. Parker is essentially stating that once a person knows the truth about poverty, they can no longer pretend to be ignorant. The questions act as a mirror, forcing the reader to examine their own prejudices.

The essay concludes not with a plea for pity, but with a call for accountability. By ending with questions, Parker ensures that the essay stays in the reader's mind long after they finish reading.